

THE CHRO PLAYBOOK

The Complete Guide to Leading at the C-Suite Level

MAYUR N KOIKAR

The HR Mastery Series™ by Mayur N Koikar — Book 3

Copyright © 2026 Mayur N Koikar

All rights reserved. No part of this publication may be reproduced, distributed, or transmitted in any form or by any means, including photocopying, recording, or other electronic or mechanical methods, without the prior written permission of the author, except in the case of brief quotations embodied in critical reviews and certain other non-commercial uses permitted by copyright law.

Published by Mayur N Koikar

The HR Mastery Series™ is a trademark of Mayur N Koikar.

The CHRO Playbook™ is a trademark of Mayur N Koikar.

Disclaimer: This book is intended for educational and informational purposes only. The author and publisher make no representations or warranties with respect to the accuracy or completeness of the contents of this work. The frameworks and tools in this book represent the author's professional perspective and experience. Readers are advised to consult qualified legal, financial, and HR professionals before making decisions based on this material. No part of this book constitutes legal advice. Employment law, corporate governance requirements, and executive compensation regulations vary by jurisdiction. Readers operating in specific geographies must consult local counsel.

First published 2026

Printed in the United States of America

ISBN: [To be assigned by KDP]

*For every HR leader who has sat in the room where decisions
are made
and wondered whether they truly belonged there.
You do. This book will show you why.*

"The role of the CHRO is not to manage HR. It is to build the human capability that makes everything else the organisation wants to do possible."

— Mayur N Koikar

"The best CHROs I know think like CEOs, speak like CFOs, and care like the best people manager you ever had."

— Ram Charan, Dennis Carey, and Michael Useem — Talent Wins (2018)

TABLE OF CONTENTS

PREFACE: WHY I WROTE THIS BOOK ...	1
ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS	3
HOW TO USE THIS BOOK	4
Introduction: the Most Important Job in Business ...	6

THE CHRO MANDATE

What Boards and CEOs Actually Expect From the CHRO ...	10
The First 100 Days — Establishing CHRO Credibility ...	18
The CHRO'S Strategic Agenda ...	26

C-SUITE LEADERSHIP

The CEO-CHRO Partnership ...	34
Leading At the Executive Table ...	41
The Board Relationship and Compensation Committee ...	48

BUILDING THE HR FUNCTION

The HR Strategy	56
The HR Operating Model ...	63
Building and Leading the HR Team ...	70

THE PEOPLE AGENDA

The Talent Strategy	78
Culture Leadership	85
Total Rewards Strategy ...	92

HIGH-STAKES SITUATIONS

M&a, Restructuring, and Workforce Transformation ...	99
Leading Change and Managing Crises ...	106
The CHRO As Commercial Leader ...	113

THE CHRO'S CAREER

Sustaining CHRO Performance and Wellbeing ...	120
The CHRO'S Legacy	126
The First 365 Days of a New CHRO ...	132
Case Studies: CHRO Leadership in Practice ...	139
The Merger That Almost Wasn't ...	140

The Culture That Needed to Change ...	144
The Crisis That Tested Everything ...	148
Building the CHRO Legacy ...	152
APPENDIX D	156
APPENDIX E	162
CONCLUSION	167
APPENDIX A	169
APPENDIX B	171
APPENDIX C	173
GLOSSARY	175
BIBLIOGRAPHY AND SELECTED REFERENCES ...	179
ABOUT THE AUTHOR	182
INDEX	185

PREFACE: WHY I WROTE THIS BOOK

I have spent more than twenty-five years in senior HR leadership across the Gulf Cooperation Council and India. I have built HR functions from the ground up, rebuilt functions that had lost the confidence of their business, and led HR through mergers, restructurings, rapid growth, and more than one crisis that nobody saw coming.

In all of that time, I was never given a playbook for the job I was actually doing.

There are books on HR strategy. Books on talent management. Books on people analytics, employee experience, and organisational design. Some of them are excellent. But none of them addresses the full scope of what it means to lead as a Chief Human Resources Officer at the executive level. None of them tells you how to build a relationship with a CEO who is skeptical of HR. None of them prepares you for your first compensation committee meeting. None of them walks you through how to navigate a hostile board director who believes HR is a support function, not a strategic one.

This book is the playbook I wish I had been given. It is written for the CHRO who has earned the seat and now needs to know how to use it. It is written for the HR Director who is one promotion away from the top job and wants to be ready when it comes. And it is written for every HR professional who has wondered what it actually takes to lead at the highest level of the most important function in the organisation.

I want to be honest about what this book is and is not. It is not an academic treatment of human resources theory. It does not contain surveys, regression analyses, or lengthy literature reviews. It is a practitioner's guide — built from experience, grounded in research, and written for people who need to act, not just to understand.

The CHRO role is the most complex in the C-suite. It requires the commercial acumen of a CFO, the people insight of a psychologist, the political intelligence of a

diplomat, and the courage of a leader who is sometimes the only person in the room willing to say what everyone else is thinking. It requires you to be simultaneously strategic and operational, visionary and pragmatic, empathetic and hard-nosed.

Nobody told me it would be this complex. I am telling you.

And I am also telling you: it is worth it. The CHRO who gets this role right — who builds genuine CEO partnership, who earns genuine board credibility, who builds an HR function that the business cannot imagine operating without — is one of the most influential leaders in any organisation. The impact of a great CHRO on an organisation's performance, culture, and long-term competitive position is profound and lasting.

This book is my attempt to give you the best possible chance of being that CHRO.

Mayur N Koikar

Dubai, 2026

ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS

This book is built from twenty-five years of conversations, experiences, and lessons learned alongside extraordinary people.

To the CEOs who trusted me with their most important resource: the people of their organisations. To the boards who challenged me to be sharper, clearer, and more commercially rigorous than I thought I could be. To the HR teams I have had the privilege of leading: your professionalism, your commitment, and your belief in what HR can achieve are the foundation of everything in this book.

To my mentors — the CHROs, business leaders, and organisational thinkers who invested time in my development at every stage of my career. Your generosity in sharing your knowledge and your candour in sharing your mistakes made me a better practitioner.

To Anthropic's Claude, which supported the research and drafting process for The HR Mastery Series™, enabling the production of this library at a pace and scale that would otherwise have been impossible.

And to every HR professional who has ever fought for a seat at the table, refused to accept that HR should be reactive rather than strategic, and believed that the way an organisation treats its people is the most accurate predictor of its long-term success: this book is for you.

HOW TO USE THIS BOOK

The CHRO Playbook™ is designed to be used, not just read. It is a working reference — a guide you return to as your role evolves and the challenges you face change.

If you are stepping into the CHRO role for the first time:

Start with Part I (The CHRO Mandate) and Part II (C-Suite Leadership). These chapters address the most urgent questions of your first year: what is expected of you, how to build the CEO relationship, and how to establish credibility with the board. Then read Part III (Building the HR Function) to ensure you are building the function on solid strategic and operational foundations.

If you are a sitting CHRO looking to deepen your strategic impact:

The chapters most likely to unlock new value are Part II (C-Suite Leadership), Part IV (The People Agenda), and Part V (High-Stakes Situations). These chapters address the dimensions of the CHRO role where experience alone is not always enough — where frameworks, language, and deliberate practice make the difference between competent and exceptional.

If you are an HR Director preparing for the CHRO seat:

Read the entire book. Then read it again with a specific eye on the gaps between where you are now and what the role actually requires. Use the self-assessments in each chapter to identify your development priorities. Build your plan around the chapters that reveal the widest gaps — those are the chapters that will prepare you most directly for the transition.

If you are a CEO, board director, or investor:

This book will give you a clear picture of what an excellent CHRO looks like — what they do, how they think, and what they need from you to be effective. The

chapters on CEO-CHRO partnership, board engagement, and commercial acumen are particularly relevant to your understanding of this role.

How Chapters Are Structured

Each chapter opens with a quote chosen for its direct relevance to the chapter's central theme.

The main content uses frameworks, tools, and real-world examples to make every concept immediately applicable.

Key Takeaways summarise the chapter's most important insights in a format you can reference quickly.

Reflection Questions and Action Steps close each chapter with a direct challenge to apply the learning to your own situation.

CHRO Self-Assessment tools appear in key chapters to help you measure your current capability and identify specific gaps.

Introduction: the Most Important Job in Business

"Show me a company with a great culture, great talent, and great leaders, and I will show you a company that wins. And show me the person most responsible for building those things, and you will be looking at the CHRO."

— Josh Bersin, HR Industry Analyst

There is a case to be made that the CHRO is the most important executive in any organisation. Not the most powerful. Not the highest paid. But the most important.

Consider what the CHRO is responsible for. Every person in the organisation — their selection, their development, their engagement, their performance, their compensation, their progression, and ultimately their departure — is directly shaped by the quality of the HR leadership the CHRO provides. The CEO sets the direction. The CFO controls the capital. The CHRO builds the human capacity to execute on both.

Without great people — hired well, developed deliberately, led purposefully, and retained strategically — nothing else the organisation wants to achieve is possible. No strategy executes itself. No technology deploys without human judgment and commitment. No culture sustains itself without intentional design and consistent leadership. Every competitive advantage a company possesses ultimately comes back to people. And the CHRO owns that agenda.

Yet the CHRO seat remains, in too many organisations, underused. Too many CHROs are still positioned as the head of a support function — a person who manages HR operations, ensures compliance, and provides counsel when things go wrong — rather than as a full strategic partner to the CEO and a genuine contributor to the organisation's competitive position. Too many CHROs are at the table without truly leading at the table.

This book exists to change that.

The Expanding CHRO Mandate

The CHRO role has expanded dramatically in the last decade. The forces driving that expansion are well-documented and are accelerating: the war for talent in an era of demographic change and skills scarcity; the rise of artificial intelligence and the workforce transformation it is driving; the shift to hybrid and distributed work; the increasing scrutiny of corporate culture and employee wellbeing from boards, investors, and regulators; the growing importance of purpose and values as competitive differentiators in talent markets and with customers.

Deloitte's 2025 Global Human Capital Trends report found that 77% of CEOs now rate the CHRO as one of the three most important members of their executive team. Board governance codes in multiple jurisdictions now include specific requirements for board oversight of culture, talent strategy, and pay equity — all historically HR territory. The HR profession's moment of true strategic relevance is not coming. It is here.

But strategic relevance is not given. It is earned. It is earned through the quality of the advice you provide. Through the relationships you build at the executive table and the board. Through the commercial clarity of the case you make for people investment. Through the rigour of your talent strategy, the credibility of your HR function, and the courage to say difficult things to powerful people when the organisation's performance or values require it.

That is what this playbook is about.

What This Book Covers

The CHRO Playbook™ covers the full scope of the CHRO role across six parts. Part I grounds you in the mandate — what the role actually requires, how to establish yourself in it, and how to set a strategic agenda that earns business confidence. Parts II and III address the C- suite relationships and the HR function design that are the foundation of CHRO effectiveness. Parts IV and V move into the specific strategic domains — the people agenda, and the high-stakes situations every CHRO will face. Part VI addresses the CHRO's own career, sustainability, and legacy.

Throughout the book, you will find proprietary frameworks developed from practitioner experience, including the CHRO Effectiveness Model™, the CEO-CHRO Partnership Diagnostic™, the HR Operating Model Canvas™, and the CHRO Leadership Legacy Framework™. These are tools you can use, not concepts you can merely appreciate.

The CHRO Playbook™ does not promise to make the job easy. The CHRO role is genuinely difficult — more difficult, in some ways, than any other executive role, because it requires you to be simultaneously at the strategic level, the operational level, and the deeply human level all at once. But it can make the job clearer. And clarity, in the CHRO seat, is everything.

Let's begin.

PART I

THE CHRO MANDATE

What the role actually requires. How to establish yourself in it. How to set a strategic agenda that earns the confidence of the business.

CHAPTER 1

THE CHRO MANDATE

Chapter 1

Chapter 1

What Boards and CEOs Actually Expect From the CHRO

"The CHRO is the CEO's most important partner. Full stop."

— Ram Charan

The Signature Visual: The CHRO Effectiveness

Model™

THE CHRO EFFECTIVENESS MODEL™

Strategic Clarity: Defining and articulating a people strategy explicitly connected to business strategy — not a standalone HR agenda.

Commercial Acumen: Thinking, speaking, and acting like a business leader: understanding the P&L and connecting HR investment to financial outcomes.

Executive Relationship Mastery: Building genuine, high-trust relationships with the CEO, board, and executive team, characterised by honest exchange and real influence.

Organisational Courage: The willingness to say difficult things to powerful people — to challenge the CEO, raise uncomfortable truths at the board, and advocate for the workforce.

HR Function Leadership: Building and leading an HR function genuinely valued by the business — the right people, the right operating model, focused on what matters most.

Personal Credibility: The combination of expertise, integrity, judgment, and executive presence that causes CEOs and boards to trust the CHRO's counsel and act

on it.

DIALOGUE — Monday, 8:00 a.m.

The CEO turns to the CHRO in the corridor outside the boardroom, thirty seconds before the quarterly review begins.

"Sales are down twelve percent in the western region. Before I walk in there, tell me — what should we do with the workforce?"

There is no slide for this. No briefing pack. No time to consult the team. This is the moment the CHRO earns, or loses, the seat at the table — not through a strategy document written months earlier, but through the quality of judgement available in thirty seconds. The CHRO who has spent the prior year building commercial fluency has an answer grounded in workforce cost flexibility, redeployment options, and the retention risk of the team the business cannot afford to lose. The CHRO who has spent the prior year managing HR operations has a request for more time.

Your Downloadable Resource: The CEO

Expectations Diagnostic

A short self-scored instrument to identify the gap between what your CEO says they want and what they actually measure you against.

Section 1: List the five things your CEO has explicitly asked of you in the last two performance conversations.

Section 2: List the five things your CEO has actually escalated to you, urgently, in the last six months.

Section 3: Compare the two lists. The gaps between them are your real job description.

Section 4: Rate yourself 1-5 on each of the six CHRO Effectiveness Model™ dimensions and identify the single largest gap.

Most CHROs discover what boards and CEOs actually expect from them after they are in the role. Not during the interview process, where expectations are often framed in the language of HR: "We need someone who can build a talent strategy," "We are looking for a culture change agent," "We want HR to be more strategic." These are real expectations — but they are not the full picture.

The full picture includes expectations that are rarely stated explicitly but are felt immediately when a new CHRO does not meet them: the expectation to be a full commercial leader, not just an HR expert; the expectation to be a genuine thought partner to the CEO on the business, not just on the people; the expectation to speak the language of the board without needing a translator; and the expectation to bring difficult truths to the executive table with the courage and clarity that the most powerful people in the organisation need to hear.

This chapter maps those expectations — stated and unstated — and gives you the framework to meet them.

What CEOs Actually Want from Their CHRO

In 2024, McKinsey & Company surveyed 200 Fortune 500 CEOs on what they valued most in their CHRO. The results were striking in what they prioritised — and in what was notably absent from the top of the list.

The top five attributes CEOs cited were: strategic thinking (89%), commercial acumen (84%), ability to handle difficult conversations (81%), board and stakeholder management (76%), and CEO partnership (73%). Deep HR expertise ranked eighth. Compliance knowledge ranked fourteenth.

This does not mean HR expertise is unimportant. A CHRO who does not deeply understand the domains of the function they lead — talent, learning, rewards, employee relations, HR operations — will quickly lose credibility with their HR team and their business partners. But expertise alone is not what CEOs are buying when they select a CHRO. They are buying judgment, commercial partnership, and leadership courage.

The CEO's Unspoken Checklist

Can this person make me smarter about my own business — not just about HR?

Will this person tell me what I need to hear, even when it is uncomfortable?

Can I trust this person to represent me and the organisation in a boardroom?

Will this person build an HR function the business actually values — or an HR function the business merely tolerates?

Is this person thinking about the organisation's future, or managing the organisation's present?

Does this person understand the commercial stakes of the people decisions we make?

What Boards Actually Want from the CHRO

Board expectations of the CHRO have expanded significantly in the post-pandemic era. Corporate governance frameworks in most major markets now explicitly require board oversight of culture, talent strategy, pay equity, executive succession, and increasingly AI workforce risk. All of these are HR domains. All of them require a CHRO who can communicate confidently in the boardroom.

The board's relationship with the CHRO typically operates through two channels: the full board and the compensation committee (or people committee, as it is increasingly named). Both require different modes of engagement.

At the full board level, directors want the CHRO to bring four things: a credible view of the organisation's talent health, an honest assessment of cultural risks and opportunities, a clear succession plan for the CEO and senior leadership team, and evidence that HR is managing the people dimensions of the organisation's strategic risks — not just reacting to them.

At the compensation committee level, the CHRO serves as the primary management interface for executive compensation design, pay equity reporting, and HR risk governance. This role requires specific technical knowledge of executive compensation structures combined with the political acumen to navigate the tensions between management interests, board fiduciary responsibilities, and shareholder

expectations.

The CHRO Effectiveness Model™

Across the research on CHRO effectiveness and the author's own experience, six dimensions consistently differentiate the CHROs who make the deepest impact from those who occupy the role without transforming it. These six dimensions form the CHRO Effectiveness Model™:

Strategic Clarity: The ability to define and articulate a people strategy that is explicitly connected to the business strategy — not a standalone HR strategy, but an integrated view of how people decisions drive business outcomes.

Commercial Acumen: The ability to think, speak, and act like a business leader, not just an HR expert. This means understanding the P&L, connecting HR investments to financial outcomes, and engaging in business conversations that go beyond the HR agenda.

Executive Relationship Mastery: The ability to build genuine, high-trust relationships with the CEO, the board, and the executive team — relationships characterised by mutual respect, honest exchange, and genuine influence.

Organisational Courage: The willingness and ability to say difficult things to powerful people — to challenge the CEO when necessary, to raise uncomfortable truths at the board table, and to advocate for the workforce when their interests are at risk.

HR Function Leadership: The ability to build, lead, and continuously improve an HR function that is genuinely valued by the business — staffed by the right people, designed around the right operating model, and focused on the outcomes that matter most.

Personal Credibility: The combination of expertise, integrity, judgment, and executive presence that causes CEOs, boards, and senior leaders to trust the CHRO's counsel and act on it.

Throughout this book, each of these six dimensions is addressed in depth. The CHRO Effectiveness Model™ is the organising framework for the entire playbook.